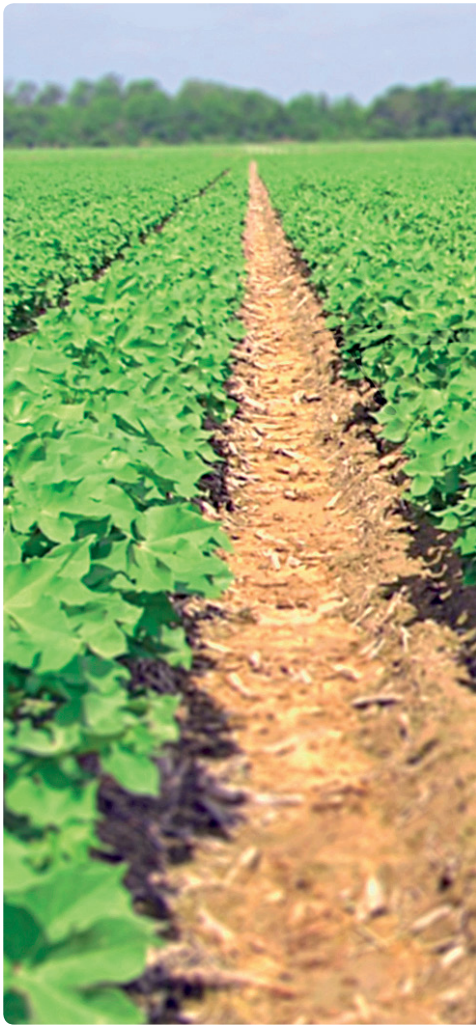
TECHNOLOGY / DRONES

THE AGE OF DRONES

A LIBERALISED GOVERNMENT POLICY HAS HELPED THE DRONE ECOSYSTEM TAKE OFF IN INDIA. HOW WILL IT CHANGE OUR LIVES?

By Ajay Sukumaran







BELIEVE IT OR NOT, THE SHAADI DRONE isn't just a popular innovation at receptions but also the most well-known avatar of unmanned flying vehicles in India in recent years. But that aerial quest for a wedding shot isn't why most drones are taking off these days. Consider the pace that Mumbai-based manufacturer ideaForge is setting--every six minutes, one of its drones is hovering somewhere over rural India, mapping villages. Or take Gurugram-based Skye Air Mobility which has clocked 1,500 flights in the last six months, mostly trial-runs for transporting goods in various settings; its experimental cargo list including pathology specimens, dry turmeric and groceries.

Every so often, those whirring rotors are in the news—like IndiaPost trying out a 46-km mail despatch between two villages in Kutch district, Gujarat, a couple of months ago. Or the civil aviation ministry in June awarding the first type certificate, or airworthiness approval, for a 'made in India' drone model—a hexacopter designed by start-up IoTechWorld Avigation for agricultural